Plural Marriage and Families in Early Utah

The Belief Files

Case File 010

Historical investigation and biblical assessment

Beyond the Message | Prepared for Jamie Dennis | November 8, 2026

Investigation summary

After the Latter-day Saint migration west, plural marriage became a publicly defended religious practice and a lived family arrangement. This case investigates the distance between an institution's explanation of marriage and the daily experience of the people expected to live it. The principal period is 1847-1890. The transition after the Manifesto belongs to Case 011. [1–2]

The evidence includes a public meeting of women defending their faith, a prominent woman's private financial concerns, a former member's critical account, demographic research, and the legal measures directed against the practice. These sources answer different questions. A speech can establish what its speaker defended. A diary can reveal a particular anxiety. Neither supplies a representative survey of every Utah household. [3–9]

The central finding is that religious commitment, affection, hardship, and unequal power could exist within the same system, and sometimes within the same family. We should neither dismiss women's defenses as meaningless nor use those defenses to silence other women's complaints. The question of divine authorization remains distinct from the question of whether people made meaningful lives within plural households.

The claim under investigation

The official LDS explanation presents plural marriage as a temporary command administered through priesthood authority. It recognizes both affection and difficulties, including financial strain and loneliness. It also distinguishes acceptance of the principle from an obligation for every individual to enter a plural union. Its estimate that two-thirds of plural husbands had two wives at a time concerns participating husbands, not all Utah men. [2]

Doctrine and Covenants 132 supplies a theological framework involving authorization, sealing, and eternal promises. Jacob 2 identifies raising up offspring as a possible exception to its stated monogamous rule. These are claims within LDS scripture; citing them establishes the rationale believers invoked, not independent verification of that rationale. [13–14]

The investigation asks three questions. What can be established about participation and family experience? How should claims about consent, prosperity, and children be tested? Does the evidence justify asking a Christian to accept plural marriage as God's command?

How this investigation weighs evidence

We must specify who is being counted, when, and for what purpose. The proportion of husbands with multiple wives is different from the proportion of all people living in their households. A person counted as having experienced a plural family during a lifetime is different from someone living in one on a particular census date.

Personal testimony requires comparable care. A woman speaking at a public defense of her community may sincerely endorse its religion while emphasizing its strengths. A woman publishing an exposé may truthfully describe harm while selecting the incidents most damaging to the institution. A private diary can be less polished, but it still records one person's circumstances and interpretation.

This case uses selected records, not a newly constructed household database. It does not claim to calculate a territory-wide divorce rate, the prevalence of abuse, or the average well-being of children. Those questions require definitions, representative sampling, and records beyond the materials examined here.

The historical timeline

Date	Evidence or development	What needs distinguishing
1847 onward	Latter-day Saint settlement in the Great Basin.	Conditions of migration and settlement from the effects of a marriage system. [1–2]
1852	Plural marriage becomes a publicly defended Church practice.	Public defense from its earlier confidential development. [1–2]
July 1, 1862	Congress enacts the Morrill Anti-Bigamy Act.	This statute from the separate Morrill land-grant law. [9]
January 13, 1870	Women speak at the Great Indignation Meeting against the proposed Cullom Bill.	Their actual arguments from a claim that every woman agreed. [5]
1872	Fanny Stenhouse publishes her critical account of Mormon life.	Her original text from the introduction to a later edited edition. [7–8]
1879	Reynolds v. United States rejects a religious-duty defense to bigamy.	A historical holding from a complete statement of current religious-liberty law. [10]
1882	The Edmunds Act adds an unlawful-cohabitation offense.	Evidence of an ongoing relationship from proof of a new marriage ceremony. [11]

Date	Evidence or development	What needs distinguishing
March-September 1890	Emmeline Wells records financial concerns; Woodruff issues the Manifesto.	An existing family's needs from the prohibition of new unions. [6,12]

Exhibit one Counting plural households

The denominator changes the story

The Church's essay estimates that about half of Utah's 1857 population experienced a plural family at some point in life, while roughly 25-30 percent lived in plural households in 1870. The first is an estimate of lifetime experience for a specified population; the second describes household residence at a date. Neither says half of Utah's husbands simultaneously had plural wives. [2]

Children matter to this distinction. One husband, two wives, and several children can place a considerable number of people in a plural household while accounting for only one plural husband. Conversely, a widow or divorced person might have experienced plural family life without being in such a household when a census was taken.

The distinction also prevents an easy numerical exaggeration. Dividing the number of plural husbands by every Church member, including children, produces a small percentage that does not answer how common the arrangement was among married adults. A calculation can be arithmetically correct and still answer the wrong question.

A demographic model is not a census

Val Lambson and Davis Bitton examined the demographic limits of sustained polygyny under plausible historical conditions. Their model constrains what a population can maintain over time. Its estimates are not a direct count of every Utah husband, and a particular community could differ from the wider population. Migration, ages at marriage, mortality, and the population chosen affect the comparison. [3]

That distinction challenges two sweeping claims: that essentially every faithful man had multiple wives, and that the practice was too rare to shape the community. A system can be practiced by a minority of husbands and still influence many women, children, church expectations, and marriage opportunities.

More children for whom?

Jacob Moorad and colleagues analyzed genealogical data from the Utah Population Database. Their study associates polygyny with greater differences in reproductive success among men; additional wives could benefit a husband's total number of children without a corresponding reproductive advantage for each wife. The study uses selected parent records and cohorts, not a complete record of all people who ever lived in Utah. [4]

Consequently, a large husband's family does not by itself establish that the arrangement increased births per woman or raised the total population above what a comparable monogamous population would have produced. Those are separate comparisons. The study also cannot decide whether a revelation occurred: reproductive outcomes and divine authorization are different questions.

Exhibit two Women speaking in public and private

The women defending their community

The January 13, 1870 Great Indignation Meeting is important evidence because women spoke for themselves. The published minutes record religious conviction, anger over proposed federal action, memories of persecution, and arguments about liberty. Eliza R. Snow defended women's participation and rejected the claim that their marriages were simply imposed captivity. [5]

Those statements deserve serious attention. Explaining every defense as an expression of stupidity or manipulation would deny the speakers agency before examining their words. They understood themselves to be believers

with a cause and a voice. Their defense of plural marriage was connected with a larger struggle over their community's legitimacy and survival.

The setting also matters. This was an organized protest against proposed legislation, not a confidential poll of women selected at random. Public advocacy gives strong evidence that the named speakers defended the practice. It does not establish that all women were satisfied, that dissent was costless, or that every household matched their description.

The proposed Cullom Bill should not be treated as an enacted law. Nor should January's religious and civic arguments be misdated as proof that Utah women were already casting civil ballots under the suffrage measure adopted the following month. The meeting's own date and purpose should remain visible. [5]

A defender's private financial concern

Emmeline B. Wells's March 4-5, 1890 diary offers a different view. She recorded a $1,000 payment from her husband toward a home, concern about receiving an adequate share, and disappointment about her prospects for housing and literary work. This was the voice of a committed and prominent Latter-day Saint woman, not simply an outside accusation. [6]

The entry does not prove that every plural wife was impoverished. It does show that public standing and religious loyalty did not eliminate practical questions about money, representation, and security. A woman's account of dependence is evidence even when she continued to believe in her religion.

It would also be unfair to assign every difficulty in Wells's life to plural marriage. A complete financial judgment would need assets, debts, previous transfers, legal arrangements, and other family records. The narrower finding is sufficient: here is a documented concern about provision within a particular family, and it cannot be erased by a general claim that plural marriage made women financially secure.

A critical account must also be heard

Fanny Stenhouse's 1872 Exposé of Polygamy presents a hostile assessment from someone with experience inside Mormon life. In chapter XVI she describes what she regarded as damaging attitudes toward women and children, including teachings that made women's future security depend on husbands. The criticism is evidence of her perspective and of the issues she chose to contest. [7]

The work is an advocacy text. Its judgments about a whole community require corroboration; a vivid passage is not a measured prevalence rate. This investigation uses the original chapter as reproduced in a later edition and distinguishes that nineteenth-century text from the modern editor's introduction. It does not treat the 1872 book and the later Tell It All as interchangeable publications. [7–8]

Snow, Wells, and Stenhouse should not be arranged into a contest in which one woman's testimony cancels the others. Their positions, occasions, and purposes differ. Together they require a more careful explanation than either universal happiness or universal passive victimhood.

Exhibit three Consent provision and family responsibility

What did a meaningful choice require?

A formal ability to refuse a marriage is relevant evidence. It is not the entire question of consent. We must also ask what a person was told about God, salvation, family loyalty, available alternatives, and the consequences of refusal. Economic dependence and sincere faith can make a formally available choice difficult without making the person's decision meaningless.

The same standard applies outside LDS history. A Christian marriage offer accompanied by threats about damnation, abandonment, or disgrace would need examination even if someone eventually said yes. This is a principle about the quality of a choice, not a presumption that every religiously motivated marriage is coerced.

Doctrine and Covenants 132 must be read in full enough to include its provisions about a first wife's consent, its exemption associated with the law of Sarah, and its warnings to Emma. One cannot establish a universal first-wife veto by quoting only the consent provision while ignoring the rest. Nor does that revelation document what every Utah wife was actually told. [13]

Provision involved more than adding an income

Family support is not established merely because a husband had property. The investigator needs to know who controlled it, how resources and time were divided, what each wife could rely on, and what happened during illness, absence, conflict, or widowhood. Wells's diary shows why those questions belong beside broad claims about social benefit. [6]

Household cooperation could be real. Women might share work, form lasting attachments, and provide companionship and care. But such benefits must be established for the families discussed. They do not remove the question of whether multiple spouses received adequate attention or whether someone carried a disproportionate share of the labor.

Likewise, the existence of divorce or remarriage is relevant to possible exit, but it does not by itself measure its practical cost. For a specific woman, children, housing, religion, reputation, and a realistic livelihood could affect her options. This case does not invent a divorce rate or infer that all women faced the same barriers.

The effects of prosecution

The federal statutes created additional pressures. The 1862 act criminalized bigamy in federal territories. The 1882 act separately penalized a man's cohabitation with more than one woman and imposed civic restrictions on people falling within its terms. Proving an ongoing prohibited relationship was different from proving the original ceremony. [9,11]

In Reynolds, the Supreme Court held that a claimed religious duty did not excuse the charged bigamy. This identifies the historical legal conflict; it

does not turn the judgment into an answer about what God commanded or a comprehensive account of today's law. [10]

A family could therefore experience hardship from more than one source: its internal distribution of time and support, frontier conditions, and government action. Investigating one source of suffering does not justify ignoring the others. Protecting women in principle and examining how prosecution affected particular women are compatible tasks.

The 1890 Manifesto addressed refraining from marriages forbidden by law. That was not identical to declaring that an existing wife or child no longer needed support. Continuing material responsibility, continuing marital relations, and entering a new union must be examined separately. Case 011 follows that distinction into the public testimony and enforcement record. [12]

Assessing the principal accounts

Witness group	What the evidence supports	What it does not establish
Women at the 1870 meeting	Named speakers publicly defended their religion and marriages. [5]	A representative measure of all women's consent or satisfaction.
Emmeline Wells	A specific private concern about money, housing, and family provision. [6]	A diagnosis of every plural household's finances.
Fanny Stenhouse	An informed participant-critic's published objections and interpretation. [7–8]	That every reported pattern was universal or independently counted.
Demographic researchers	Defined models and findings from identified datasets. [3–4]	A complete census of family experience or a verdict on revelation.

Witness group	What the evidence supports	What it does not establish
Legislators and courts	What the statutes prohibited and what a court held. [9–11]	That legal victory establishes theological truth.

The reliability question is therefore claim-specific. A critic can be right about a particular harm without having a fair account of every believer. A defender can be sincere about her own marriage without knowing all private experiences. Comparison is more useful than assigning each witness a permanent label of reliable or unreliable.

The strongest LDS argument

The strongest faithful account begins with the belief that God sometimes commands a difficult exception to a standing rule. Within that framework, plural marriage could be a demanding vocation rather than a search for convenience. Women's public advocacy, enduring family attachments, and costly religious loyalty deserve a place in that explanation. [2,5,13–14]

A thoughtful defender need not claim that every household was happy or that every believer was required to participate. Human failures would not, by themselves, disprove a divine command. Nor would hostile legislation automatically settle the religious question.

That argument is more substantial than saying that every man simply wanted more wives. Its unresolved premise remains the claimed command. Evidence that people believed it, defended it, or sacrificed for it is not independent evidence that God gave it. A Christian must still examine the authority and teaching rather than allowing the cost of obedience to authenticate the instruction.

Competing explanations

A temporary divine command lived imperfectly. This explains why some participants regarded sacrifice as obedience and why family difficulties did not necessarily end their faith. It requires independent grounds for accepting the claimed revelation, not just the existence of sincere followers.

A religious institution sustaining a distinctive social order. Shared belief, leadership authority, family alliances, and outside opposition could reinforce the practice. This can explain patterns without requiring every participant to be cynical. It must still account for differences between households and for people who resisted or left.

A mixture of conviction, benefit, and unequal power. Some individuals could receive companionship or material support while others experienced loss or pressure. The same husband could bear heavy responsibilities and possess greater marital authority. This explanation fits varied experience but does not independently decide every person's motives.

A single story of either liberation or exploitation. Such accounts may capture a real part of the record, but they become inadequate when presented as the entire history. Public defenses, private financial worries, critical testimony, and demographic limits require more than one category. [3–8]

Motives benefits and costs

Questions about benefit are legitimate when applied evenly. Plural husbands might acquire larger families and extended alliances; they could also face divided responsibilities and prosecution. Women might gain affiliation and support while bearing loneliness, rivalry, or insecurity. None of those possibilities should be assigned to a named person without evidence about that person's circumstances.

The institution could gain cohesion from a practice that distinguished insiders from outsiders. Opponents could gain political influence or a persuasive public cause by presenting it as a national danger. Benefit alone

does not establish deception on either side. It identifies an incentive to examine alongside documents and conduct.

Sacrifice likewise does not prove truth. People in conflicting religions accept costs for sincere convictions. The useful question is whether a claim remains well supported after its benefits, costs, and pressures have been examined.

A biblical assessment

Read the difficult texts honestly

Genesis contains plural households, and Old Testament law regulates circumstances arising from them. Those texts prevent the claim that plural marriage is absent from the Bible or that Scripture records no accommodation of it. Description, regulation, and a command to Christians are nevertheless distinct categories. [15]

Jesus answers a question about divorce by returning to creation and the union of two becoming one flesh. The evangelical assessment here understands that appeal, together with the New Testament's marital teaching, as establishing an exclusive marital pattern. This is an interpretation of the texts in context, not a claim that Matthew 19 directly narrates nineteenth-century Utah. [16]

The strongest LDS objection is that God may authorize an exception. The decisive issue then becomes whether this particular exception has adequate authorization. Appealing to Abraham's household does not itself establish that a later religious leader may reproduce it.

Judge provision by the obligations of love

Ephesians 5 calls a husband to self-giving care; its appeal to Christ is an obligation to love rather than permission to demand unilateral sacrifice from a wife. First Corinthians 7:3-5 speaks in reciprocal terms about marital obligations. First Timothy 5:8 gives serious weight to providing for one's household. [17–18]

These passages make concrete questions unavoidable: Was care dependable? Were duties reciprocal? Were promises used to serve the other person, or to protect the person with greater authority? The same questions apply to monogamous Christian marriages. A Christian label cannot excuse neglect or coercion.

Test the claimed exception and state the gospel clearly

Acts 5:29 shows that obedience to God can conflict with human commands; Romans 13 also gives civil authority serious weight. Neither passage lets an investigator skip the question of what God actually commanded. Civil disobedience is not self-authenticating simply because its participants describe it as religious. [19]

From the evangelical perspective used here, salvation rests on God's grace received through faith in Christ, not on entry into a particular plural household. Ephesians 2:8-10 joins grace with a resulting life of good works; it does not make a religious leader's marriage arrangement the basis of eternal security. [20]

The Christian response should therefore combine a clear disagreement over claimed authorization with respect for the people who lived within that claim. The object is a truthful account and a clear witness to Christ, not humiliation of a modern LDS family.

Findings and confidence

Finding	Confidence	Basis or limit
Plural family life cannot be described by one universal personal experience.	High	Public defenses, private concerns, and criticism differ in meaningful ways. [5–8]
Household population and the percentage of plural husbands are different measures.	High	Distinct denominators and demographic models. [2–4]

Finding	Confidence	Basis or limit
A large husband's family does not establish more births per woman.	High	The comparison requires female and population measures, not only male totals. [4]
Sincere advocacy establishes neither universal consent nor divine authorization.	High as a met hodological finding	A speaker's belief is not a survey or independent revelation evidence.
Government action placed real legal pressures on participating families.	High	The statutes and Reynolds decision. [9–11]
The exact distribution of benefit and harm across all households is established here.	Not established	Selected testimony and studies are not a comprehensive household audit.

Overall assessment

Early Utah plural marriage was a consequential system sustained by religious teaching and lived by people whose experiences differed. The evidence requires recognition of women's advocacy and of the needs and injuries they recorded. Neither universal contentment nor a claim that every woman lacked agency survives careful comparison.

The historical evidence establishes participation, conviction, conflict, and responsibility. It does not independently establish the divine command claimed for the practice. From the Christian perspective stated here, the appeal to restored authority does not supply sufficient grounds to set aside the New Testament pattern of marriage and the gospel's assurance in Christ.

The next investigation turns from life within the practice to its discontinuation. A complete account must ask what the Manifesto promised, what continued, who approved exceptions, and how the later prohibition was enforced.

Read compare and discuss

1. When someone gives a percentage, who is being counted: husbands, wives, children, households, or a lifetime cohort?
2. What does the 1870 meeting establish about its named speakers? What would require a different kind of evidence?
3. How does Wells's private concern complicate a broad claim about economic security?
4. What would you need to verify before generalizing from Stenhouse's criticism to an entire population?
5. How would you distinguish a formal opportunity to refuse from a practically meaningful choice?
6. What is the strongest version of the faithful LDS explanation? Which premise still requires testing?
7. Read Matthew 19:3-9 and 1 Corinthians 7:3-5. What obligations do they place on husbands as well as wives?
8. How could a Christian state a disagreement about marriage authority while listening carefully to an LDS friend's family history?

Accuracy notes and further research

This case extends the supplied general plural-marriage packet with identified primary testimony and research. It does not claim to reproduce an unseen complete branch manuscript or to have reviewed every family archive. The packet's broad claims are treated as research leads, not as substitutes for the records cited here. [1]

Keep the following qualifications in any lesson, app excerpt, or future book chapter. Lifetime exposure is not point-in-time prevalence. A demographic model is not a census. A public speech is not a representative poll. A private financial worry is not a population-wide poverty rate. Availability of divorce is not a measurement of the cost of leaving.

Further work could compare representative local household samples, complete family financial records, applications for divorce, children's accounts, and correspondence from both satisfied and dissatisfied participants. Such work may refine the distribution of outcomes without automatically settling the theological question.

Sources and reading

[1] Jamie Dennis, supplied LDS Gospel Topics Essays research compilation, general plural-marriage packet, physical PDF pages 231-241. Source material for the series; its summary claims require checking against the documents below.

[2] The Church of Jesus Christ of Latter-day Saints, "Plural Marriage and Families in Early Utah," Gospel Topics Essays. Official institutional explanation, demographic estimates, and participation qualifications. Open source

[3] Val Lambson and Davis Bitton, "Demographic Limits of Nineteenth-Century Mormon Polygyny," BYU Studies Quarterly 51, no. 4 (2012), article 3. A demographic model, not a direct census. Open source

[4] Jacob A. Moorad, Daniel E. L. Promislow, Ken R. Smith, and Michael J. Wade, "Mating system change reduces the strength of sexual selection in an American frontier population of the 19th century," Evolution and Human Behavior 32, no. 2 (2011): 147-155. DOI: 10.1016/j.evolhumbehav.2010.10.004. Abstract and methods consulted; parent-record selection limits generalization. Open source

[5] "Minutes of Great Indignation Meeting, January 13, 1870," published in Deseret Evening News, January 14-15, 1870; reproduced in The First Fifty Years of Relief Society, Church Historian's Press, document 3.13. Selected speeches, especially Eliza R. Snow's, consulted in context. Open source

[6] Emmeline B. Wells, diary, March 4-5, 1890, The Diaries of Emmeline B. Wells, Church Historian's Press. Contemporary entries concerning the payment, housing, and literary ambitions. Open source

[7] Fanny Stenhouse, Exposé of Polygamy: A Lady's Life among the Mormons (1872), chapter XVI, original printed pages 118-123, in the later edited edition available through the Library of Congress. Selected original chapter consulted; the modern introduction is distinct. Open source

[8] Utah State University Press, Exposé of Polygamy: A Lady's Life among the Mormons, edited by Linda Wilcox DeSimone (2008). Edition history and author context. Open source

[9] Morrill Anti-Bigamy Act, July 1, 1862, ch. 126, 12 Stat. 501-502. Historical statutory text, transcribed at Wikisource. Open source

[10] Reynolds v. United States, 98 U.S. 145 (1879), Library of Congress, United States Reports. The holding and religious-duty issue are cited as historical law, not current legal advice. Open source

[11] Edmunds Act, March 22, 1882, ch. 47, 22 Stat. 30-32, especially sections 3 and 8. Historical statutory text, transcribed at Wikisource. Open source

[12] Official Declaration 1, Doctrine and Covenants. Manifesto and October 6, 1890 acceptance; the appended addresses are separately identified on the page. Open source

[13] Doctrine and Covenants 132, especially verses 19, 51-56, and 61-65. Read the consent provision with the law-of-Sarah exemption. Open source

[14] Jacob 2:23-35, Book of Mormon. The stated monogamous rule, claimed exception, and concern about family harm. Open source

[15] Genesis 16; 29-30; Exodus 21:10-11; Deuteronomy 21:15-17. KJV. Narrative and legal contexts must be distinguished from a New Testament command.

[16] Genesis 2:24; Matthew 19:3-9. KJV. Creation, divorce, and the two becoming one flesh.

[17] Ephesians 5:21-33; Colossians 3:19. KJV. Self-giving marital responsibility and the rejection of bitterness toward a wife.

[18] 1 Corinthians 7:3-5; 1 Timothy 5:8. KJV. Reciprocal obligations and household provision.

[19] Acts 5:29; Romans 13:1-7. KJV. Obedience to God and the responsibilities connected with civil authority.

[20] Ephesians 2:8-10; 1 John 5:11-13. KJV. Grace, faith, good works, and assurance in Christ.